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KHAN AT THE SESSION

the people, it would start to work its magic. New markets did enormous business. Dollar 100 million in 320 3D screens in Russia, \$200 million out of 600 3D screens in China. 3D is a significant part for the success of *Avatar*. Now Hollywood has started to stampede towards it but they're doing it the wrong way by taking 2D movies and switching them to 3D.

Consumer electronics companies are all making 40-50-60 inch plasma and LED screens to show 3D. That's great but you have nothing to show on them. But they have managed to create the content gap which is exactly the opposite of what we had in theatres. In theatres, we had more movies than screens and now we are going to have five to six million of TV sets being shipped this year which can show 3D but we don't have content to run on them. So what will happen? I predict network, satellite and cable companies will start finding ways to deliver 3D to home and this is going to happen very fast. A lot of other things are required, including funding and infrastructure—from around 50 cameras now to thousands of cameras to be able to shoot sporting events, live entertainment and scripted entertainment for television. What I can predict is what effect it will have on the movie-going experience because one of the most fascinating things that came out of *Avatar* and some other 3D films is that people began going back to cinemas after years of a passionate affair with films on smaller devices. People need immediate access and this will now lessen their dependence on pirated videos. The pendulum is swinging in the other direction and people now want to go back to the

wide screens and experience it with a room full of people. Though *Avatar* is the highest grossing film of all time, it is also the most pirated film in history. But it hasn't hurt the box office. I think this is really wonderful as it is reinstating cinema back to the stature it should always have.

But 3D is not the success of *Avatar*. I believe *Avatar* works because of its story, its characters and actors who touched the hearts of people around the world. It's the emotions, themes and the spirituality of the film. It's good old-fashioned storytelling and good old-fashioned acting. It's a personal film for me, studded with my feelings of when I was a teenager and what I thought about our treatment of the planet and the nature of war. *Avatar* is affecting people around the world and I think I not only have an opportunity but the duty to follow-up with that in terms of raising consciousness about the changes we have to make in our society to protect our planet. We have groups from the Amazon and from India as well where tribals are being displaced by mining interests. We are flooded with phone calls and emails from people who say "that's my reality".

Technology is a wave. As a filmmaker, you can surf and pick up tremendous speed and power. If you don't, it's going to break over you, crash down on your head and leave you behind. But technology isn't the most important thing. It's the story, the character, the heart and soul of the movie that's most important. Movies are made from the heart and not by computers. As the Na'vis say in *Avatar*, "May the great mother smile on us all."

DISCUSSION

JAMES CAMERON	FILMMAKER, EDITOR, INVENTOR
AAMIR KHAN	ACTOR, DIRECTOR, PRODUCER
AROON PURIE	SESSION CHAIRPERSON

Khan: I had always imagined that whenever I directed my first film, I would need to understand two areas better: sound and visual effects. But we don't invest at all in research and development in India. I will probably want to come to Cameron's studio in Los Angeles to understand the process of how a shot is finally turned out from start to the end. I ended up directing my first film by accident. So my plans of learning in these two areas are yet to happen. I believe the core responsibility of cinema is to entertain. But I also believe that you can't entertain unless you engage me in some way. Cinema is one of the youngest art forms and essentially we are telling stories. And in that story, if there is something of value that we are conveying, it becomes much more interesting for an audience. We have to convey it in an interesting manner, even if it is something as simple as a film on triumph of the human spirit like *Lagaan* or about child care and education like *Taare Zameen Par*, which inspires you, gives you courage or perhaps, hope.

Purie: Do both of you make films for yourself or do you have an audience in mind?